

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

OpenAI, the maker of ChatGPT, confidentially filed for an **initial public offering**. In March the AI lab closed a funding round to raise \$122bn at a valuation of \$852bn. The [giga-IPO](#) follows filings by Anthropic, a rival AI company, and SpaceX, Elon Musk's rocketry-come-AI firm. Sam Altman (pictured), OpenAI's boss, [fended off a legal challenge](#) from Mr Musk last month, clearing a hurdle to a public listing.

Israel and **Iran** agreed to stop exchanging air strikes, but both threatened to retaliate if the other side resumed attacks. **Donald Trump** said peace negotiations were "proceeding" and that a naval blockade of Iran remained in place. Israel reportedly stopped its attacks following [a request from the American president](#) after fighting reignited on Sunday. The price of Brent crude fell to around \$94.

Asian stocks rebounded after a sell-off of chipmaking firms on Monday led to their biggest drop since March. In early trading South Korea's KOSPI climbed 3.9% and Japan's Nikkei rose by 1.0%. American stock markets also closed higher. Both markets were also reassured by Iran's and Israel's announcements.

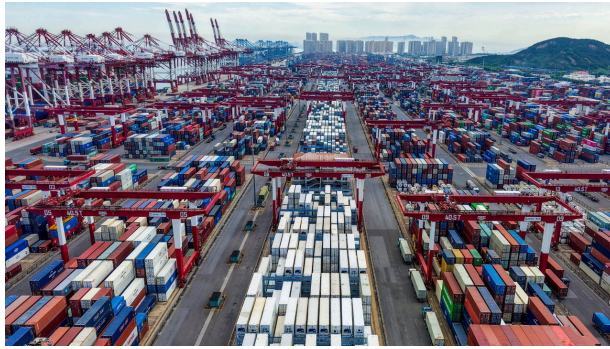
A federal judge ruled that Mr Trump's [proposed \\$100,000 charge](#) on new applications for **H-1B visas** was unlawful. Several states sued the Trump administration after the fee was announced in September. The visa is mostly used by technology firms hiring foreign graduates. Separately, American immigration officials barred the entry of a Somali referee who was due to officiate at the World Cup. No reason was given.

The **Pentagon** added around two dozen **Chinese businesses** to its list of national-security risks. BYD, the world's biggest electric-car maker, and internet firms such as Baidu and Alibaba were among those accused of aiding China's military. They vehemently denied the charge. The firms will be barred from doing business with America's armed forces. The announcement may complicate upcoming summits planned between the countries' leaders.

Germany and **France** abandoned plans to jointly build a next-generation **fighter jet**. The Future Combat Air System, which also involves Spain, had been [plagued by bickering](#) between French and German defence firms, including over how to split up the work. Germany's government said that Friedrich Merz, the chancellor, and Emmanuel Macron, France's president, concluded that the companies were unable to "come together".

Apple announced improvements to its artificial-intelligence tools at its Worldwide Developers Conference, including a long-delayed overhaul of **Siri**. The digital assistant will soon use AI to offer personalised chatbot services to its users; its familiar voice is also becoming customisable. Investors' reactions to the updates were muted. John Ternus [takes over from Tim Cook](#) as Apple's boss on September 1st.

Figure of the day: 2,414, the size of an Estonian startup's fleet of pizza-delivery robots in 2025. [Read the full story.](#)



Photograph: Getty Images

China's confidence problem

China made headlines when it declared that its trade surplus last year [exceeded \\$1trn](#). On Tuesday its customs administration reported another strong figure: exports grew by 19.4% in May compared with a year earlier.

The country's mercantile success has stoked fear and anger abroad. But it has not encouraged confidence and spending at home. Retail sales in China are faltering. Car sales fell by over a fifth year on year in May. Although the Iran war has pushed up the prices of fuel and other inputs, firms have not been able to pass higher costs on to their customers. Figures released on Wednesday will probably show that consumer prices rose only modestly last month year on year. The government ought to do more to bolster consumer confidence by stabilising the property market and boosting rural pensions. But its policies are better at wooing foreign buyers than soothing buyers at home.



Photograph: 11th Marine Expeditionary Unit

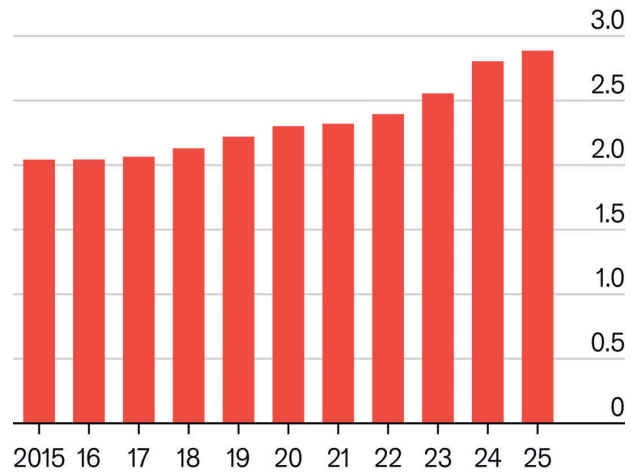
Guns up, rules down

On Tuesday SIPRI, a Swedish think-tank, will present its annual review of developments in military technology and international security at Sweden's parliament. The context is striking. Global military spending reached a record \$2.9trn last year. The militarisation of space continues to outpace international regulation. Weapons and command-and-control systems increasingly incorporate artificial intelligence, which could also make it easier to develop biological and chemical weapons.

SIPRI's sharpest warning concerns [nuclear weapons](#). The yearbook says that countries are modernising and expanding their nuclear arsenals as confidence erodes in the Non-Proliferation Treaty, which bans non-nuclear powers from obtaining the weapons. Iran is resisting American demands that it relinquish its stockpile of highly enriched uranium. In Japan and South Korea pressure to join the nuclear club has grown. SIPRI argues that the world is at a watershed. New START, the sole remaining treaty limiting America's and Russia's deployed strategic nuclear forces, expired in February.

Stocking up

World, military spending, \$trn, 2025 prices



Source: SIPRI



Photograph: AP

Preparing for the Maine event

Maine is important to America's Democrats. The state has one of four Senate seats they will likely need to win if they are to [regain control of the chamber](#) in November's midterm elections. The Republican incumbent, Susan Collins, has held the job for almost three decades. In primaries on Tuesday voters will probably select Graham Platner as the Democratic candidate to take her on. A 41-year-old Marine infantryman turned oyster farmer, Mr Platner has woven an outsider, anti-elite narrative.

But [a series of scandals](#)—including reports that he sent explicit messages to women while married, and allegations of abuse by an ex-girlfriend (which he denies)—has made him a riskier bet. Mr Platner has sought to move on from his past, which he says has been “weaponised”. High-ranking Democrats have cautiously stood by him. For now, he is polling ahead of Ms Collins in the general election. The test is whether voters will move on with him.



Photograph: A24

Gen Z behind the camera

In recent weeks the global box office has been dominated not by Hollywood veterans but by American YouTubers in their 20s. “Obsession”, Curry Barker’s second film, was made for just under \$1m and has grossed \$225m. “Backrooms”, Kane Parsons’s debut feature, has taken almost \$215m and become a hit in 25 countries.

Both films update classic horror tropes for a generation worried about isolation, insecure housing and bleak career prospects. In “Backrooms”, a divorced alcoholic living in his furniture shop stumbles into a sinister labyrinth. In “Obsession”, a socially awkward man uses a talisman to make his friend fall in love with him, with terrifying consequences. Both movies end with acts of self-destruction; in the cruel world of these stories, the characters’ best option is to surrender. Many Gen Zers say they feel similarly hopeless. The creators of these blockbusters, though, must be feeling that the future looks bright.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Stanley Park is a large public park in which North American city?

Monday: What is the capital of the Mexican state of Nuevo Leon?

A word in earnest is as good as a speech.

Charles Dickens